

Xiaochuan Li

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Computational cognitive science and language model interpretability. Current focus: epistemic modality.

EDUCATION

University of Technology Nuremberg <i>M.Sc. Human and Artificial Intelligence</i> Thesis in progress: modal language in preschool children (supervisor: Charlotte Grosse Wiesmann). Coursework: cognitive psychology, experimental design and statistics, interpretability, deep learning.	Nuremberg, Germany <i>Oct. 2025 – exp. 2027</i>
University of Marburg <i>Preparatory studies: German for graduate study</i>	Marburg, Germany <i>2024 – 2025</i>
Shenzhen University <i>B.A. Philosophy</i> Thesis: Leibniz's <i>characteristica universalis</i> (supervisor: Zang Yong).	Shenzhen, China <i>2020 – 2024</i>

RESEARCH

Epistemic modality in people and language models <i>Current focus · how modal expressions are understood and used, by people and by language models</i>	<i>2026 –</i>
FORMAL ANALYSIS	Three Ways of Leaving <i>p</i> Unsettled: compares <i>might p</i> , <i>might p</i> or <i>might not p</i> and <i>I don't know whether p</i> by the replies each licenses. <i>In development.</i>
HUMAN STUDY	M.Sc. thesis: modal language in preschool children, added to an ongoing PhD project at MPI CBS Leipzig on how they reason about possibilities. <i>In planning.</i>
COMPUTATIONAL MODEL	Modal choice: fits three competing accounts of the choice between <i>must</i> and <i>might</i> to published human data. <i>In development.</i>

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Prompt framing and latent control states in language models · year-long project course with M. Roth (UTN) and S. Ostermann (DFKI); causal interventions in 7B–14B models, utilitarian-framing branch	<i>2026–27</i>
Fact-checking after ChatGPT exposure · human study, class-wide experiment (N = 49); my part: data analysis	<i>2025–26</i>
Cross-lingual ProtoBias · VLM evaluation, single-author course project, about 12,600 judgments	<i>2026</i>
Street-view country classification · team course project, Deep Learning; my part: CNN training and analysis	<i>2026</i>
Learning difficulties in primary-school children · with the Shenzhen Learning Disorders Association: test items, response data, individual plans	<i>2021</i>

PAPERS AND MANUSCRIPTS

Li, X. (2026). Typicality in referent choice: What the description leaves open. Working paper. lingbuzz/010343 , doi:10.5281/zenodo.22855036
Prompt framing and latent control states in language models. Manuscript in preparation with M. Roth (UTN) and S. Ostermann (DFKI).

EMPLOYMENT

University of Technology Nuremberg <i>IT Service Desk (part-time)</i> Designed and delivered IT onboarding training for incoming students, with follow-up one-to-one support; also system installation, service reporting, and inventory.	Nuremberg, Germany <i>Apr. 2026 – present</i>
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SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Programming	Python (PyTorch, Hugging Face Transformers, pandas, scikit-learn), Git, LaTeX
Methods	PsychoPy/Pavlovia, JASP; probing, activation patching, steering (working proficiency)
Languages	Mandarin Chinese (native), German (C1), English (C1), Japanese (learning)